THE BELIEF FILES · 00 · START HERE

Islam & biblical Christianity

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Begin with the central question

Islam and Christianity both speak about the one God, revelation, prophets, judgment, and Jesus. Shared names make a conversation possible. They also make definitions necessary. What does each source actually claim about God, the identity of Jesus, and the way people are reconciled to God?

This collection examines those claims from an evangelical and Trinitarian Christian perspective. It distinguishes a source's teaching, the historical evidence relevant to that teaching, and the Christian theological assessment. A disagreement about doctrine does not justify treating a Muslim neighbor as a stereotype.

The Qur'an presents Muhammad as God's messenger and the seal of the prophets, and it places its message in relation to earlier revelation. The New Testament identifies Jesus as the incarnate Word and places his death and resurrection at the center of the gospel. The investigation begins with that claimed continuity and those substantial differences. [Q2; Q5; B1; B2]

How to use this collection

Begin here for the main questions. Then open Case File 001, Muhammad and the Prophetic Claim. Its sections move through the claim, historical exhibits, witnesses, competing explanations, Scripture, assessment, and discussion. Citation codes open the corresponding source notes; the Sources section gives direct reading links.

Read a passage in context before evaluating it. An English rendering of the Qur'an includes translation choices; explanatory words added by a translator should not automatically be attributed to the Arabic text. Biblical references in this collection use the KJV. No English translation resolves every interpretive question on its own.

Identify whose position is being described. The selected hadith are from prominent Sunni collections. Sunni, Shia, and Ibadi traditions should not be treated as interchangeable, and an individual Muslim may understand an issue differently from an author being discussed. The Amman Message is one influential statement recognizing several legal traditions; it is

not a survey of every Muslim's beliefs. [H1; H2; H3; M1]

God and the identity of Jesus

The Qur'an emphasizes God's oneness and uniqueness. Christianity also confesses one God. The disagreement concerns the identity of that one God and the place of Jesus, rather than a Christian confession of three separate gods. In the Trinitarian framework used here, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are personally distinct and share the one divine being. Christian language about the Son does not assert that God physically fathered a child. [Q1; B1; B6]

Question	Islamic source claim	Biblical Christian comparison
Who is God?	Qur'an 112 emphasizes divine oneness, uniqueness, and the denial of begetting. [Q1]	John 1 identifies the Word as both with God and God; Matthew 28 names Father, Son, and Holy Spirit together. [B1; B6]
Who is Jesus?	Qur'an 4:171 identifies Jesus as Messiah and messenger while rejecting divine sonship and language about three. Interpretive additions in an English translation must be identified. [Q3]	John 1:1-18 identifies the Word who became flesh; Hebrews 1:1-4 describes the Son's relation to creation and God's revelation. [B1; B5]
What must be investigated?	How does the Qur'an understand earlier revelation and Christian claims? [Q3; Q5]	Does the New Testament's account of Jesus support the later message's claim of continuity? [B1; B2; B5]

Do not settle this discussion by asking only whether both religions honor Jesus. They assign him different identities and roles. Ask what each person means by Messiah, Son, messenger, worship, and one God, then examine the passages supporting those definitions.

The cross resurrection and salvation

Paul's summary in 1 Corinthians 15:1-19 centers on Christ's death for sins, burial, resurrection, and reported appearances. The ordinary Islamic reading of Qur'an 4:157-158 denies that Jesus' opponents killed or crucified him and affirms God's raising him. The passage does not itself name a substitute. Detailed interpretations require their own sources. These accounts disagree about an event at the center of the Christian gospel. [Q4; B2]

Historical inquiry can examine the sources for Jesus' death and resurrection, their dates, dependence, and testimony. It must distinguish Paul's surviving report about other witnesses from separate surviving statements by every person he mentions. A historical argument and a confession that God acted are related questions, with different kinds of reasoning.

For salvation, avoid reducing Islam to a simple formula of earning heaven. Qur'an 39:53 speaks of divine mercy and forgiveness, Qur'an 99:6-8 connects deeds with judgment, and Sahih Muslim 2816c states the necessity of God's mercy rather than reliance on deeds alone. These sources must be examined together with the wider teaching of the relevant tradition. [Q6; Q7; H3]

Ephesians 2:1-10 presents salvation by grace through faith and describes good works as the resulting purpose of the believer's life. The evangelical comparison here understands reconciliation through Christ's saving work, rather than treating moral achievement as the basis for justification. The significant question concerns the place of Jesus' death and resurrection, alongside how each tradition relates mercy, faith, repentance, and obedience. [B2; B3]

Scripture revelation and authority

The Qur'an presents itself in relation to earlier scripture, and Qur'an 33:40 identifies Muhammad's prophetic role. These passages establish what the text claims. Evaluating the claim requires asking how it is authenticated and how its teaching relates to the earlier message it addresses. [Q2; Q5]

The Christian criterion used here includes Galatians 1:6-12: a later messenger's claim must be tested against the apostolic gospel. Paul also asserts revelation as the source of his own commission. A fair inquiry therefore examines his claim and evidence rather than assuming that an asserted revelation answers every historical question. [B4]

Source or term	How it helps	Question to keep open
Qur'an	Establishes the content of the scriptural claim being examined.	What is asserted, what is translated, and what interpretation is being supplied?
Hadith	Preserves attributed reports about Muhammad and the early community.	Who transmits the report, in which collection, and how is it evaluated?
Sunnah	Refers to the normative prophetic example; hadith are important evidence for it.	Which tradition's account and interpretation are being used?
Biography and later commentary	Supplies narratives and explanations for comparison.	How close is the source to the event, and what earlier material can be recovered?
Biblical texts	State the Christian claims and the project's theological criteria.	What does the passage mean in context, and what supports the historical claim?

Preservation of a text and divine origin are separate claims. A well-preserved message still requires an argument for its truth; a textual variant requires assessment of its actual significance. Apply those distinctions to both Islamic and Christian sources.

Origins and the evidence we examine

The conventional historical outline places Muhammad's career in western Arabia in the early seventh century, with the migration to Medina in 622 and his death in 632. The familiar account of the first calling is transmitted in later Islamic literature, including the report attributed to Aisha in Sahih al-Bukhari 3. A source may preserve earlier information without being a contemporary record of every event it describes. [A1; H1]

Case File 001 separates a historical person and movement from reported experiences, and those experiences from the claim that God authorized the message. It examines Muslim transmitted reports alongside early external notices and material evidence. It also presents a strong Muslim argument before assessing alternatives.

Our recurring questions are practical: What happened? Who reports it? When was the account recorded? Is another account independent? What does the source establish, and what conclusion goes beyond it? A later compilation date does not prove that every report was invented then. Several repetitions of one report do not automatically provide several independent witnesses.

Motives receive the same care. Documented authority, wealth, relationships, hardship, and sacrifice may matter to an investigation. Benefit alone does not establish fraud; suffering alone does not authenticate revelation. Disagreement with a religious claim does not provide a medical diagnosis or direct access to a founder's intentions.

Read compare and discuss

For a first conversation, use three paired readings. Take one pair at a time and allow the other person to explain the source they recognize.

1. Read Qur'an 112 and John 1:1-18. What does each passage affirm about God, and where do the claims diverge? [Q1; B1]

2. Read Qur'an 4:157-158 and 1 Corinthians 15:1-19. What is asserted about Jesus' death, and what kind of evidence would help evaluate the disagreement? [Q4; B2]

3. Read Qur'an 39:53, Sahih Muslim 2816c, and Ephesians 2:1-10. How are mercy, human response, good works, and Christ's role understood? [Q6; H3; B3]

Ask which question matters most to your conversation partner. Clarify a term before disputing it. State the Christian disagreement plainly and allow the person to disagree. Respect a request to end the discussion. First Peter 3:15-16 joins giving reasons with gentleness, respect, and a good conscience. [B6]

For personal study or a small group, write one claim in a single sentence. Record its source, distinguish direct quotation from paraphrase, list the evidence that would strengthen or weaken it, and identify what remains unresolved. The aim is an accountable judgment, with room to correct a mistake.

Continue the investigation

Open Case File 001, Muhammad and the Prophetic Claim, from the Islam collection page. Begin with its overview, then examine the exhibits and source notes before reading the overall assessment. The complete case PDF is available in the reader. The supporting research packet is available on the collection page for lesson ideas and further study.

Further historical cases and a closing conversation guide will be added as they are completed. Research packet numbers and published case-file numbers describe different kinds of work. This introduction and Case File 001 are the current published reading path.

Sources and reading

This introduction adapts the project's Islam 00 research and completed Case File 001. Qur'an and hadith passages are paraphrased, not reproduced as quotations. The referenced English Qur'an presentation is The Clear Quran on Quran.com. These references identify the claims discussed, rather than independent proof of their divine origin.

Q1 Qur'an 112:1-4. Oneness, uniqueness, and begetting. Read

Q2 Qur'an 33:40. Muhammad as messenger and seal of the prophets. Read

Q3 Qur'an 4:171. Jesus, messengership, sonship, and three. Translation expansions require separate attention. Read

Q4 Qur'an 4:157-158. Killing, crucifixion, and God's raising Jesus. The text does not name a substitute. Read

Q5 Qur'an 5:48. The Qur'an's relationship to earlier scripture and its asserted authority. Read

Q6 Qur'an 39:53. Divine mercy and forgiveness; read the surrounding passage. Read

Q7 Qur'an 99:6-8. Deeds and judgment. Read

H1 Sahih al-Bukhari 3. Report attributed to Aisha on the beginning of revelation. A transmitted account, not a contemporary document from the cave. Read

H2 Sahih Muslim 8a. The Gabriel report on faith, practice, and excellence in worship. A Sunni collection reference. Read

H3 Sahih Muslim 2816c. God's mercy and deeds in entry to paradise. Read

B1 John 1:1-18, KJV. The Word, creation, and incarnation. Read KJV

B2 1 Corinthians 15:1-19, KJV. The gospel and reported resurrection appearances. Read KJV

B3 Ephesians 2:1-10, KJV. Grace, faith, and good works. Read KJV

B4 Galatians 1:6-12, KJV. The gospel criterion and Paul's revelation claim. Read KJV

B5 Hebrews 1:1-4, KJV. The identity and revelatory role of the Son. Read KJV

B6 Matthew 28:16-20 and 1 Peter 3:15-16, KJV. Father, Son, and Holy Spirit; the manner of Christian witness. Read Matthew · Read 1 Peter

M1 The Amman Message, The Three Points, version 1. An influential statement recognizing several Muslim legal traditions, not a universal survey of belief. Read

A1 Chase Robinson, The rise of Islam 600-705, The New Cambridge History of Islam. The chapter summary supplies limited chronological orientation; no full chapter review is claimed. Read summary